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The Japan National Stadium in Tokyo has a special place in the history of Indian athletics. In 2021, Neeraj Chopra won the country's first Olympic gold medal in track and field when he hurled his javelin to a distance of 87.58m at the multipurpose venue. Unfortunately, Neeraj could celebrate the moment only with members of the Indian contingent and a select group of journalists, as the arena bore a sorry look due to the COVID-19 pandemic.

Four years later, Neeraj, along with 18 other Indian athletes, returns to the same stadium, which will host the World Athletics Championships from September 13 to 21.

The 27-year-old Neeraj has already won everything there is to be won — an achievement unfathomable for Indian athletics not so long ago.

And now, he is at it again.

While he could not defend his title at the Paris Olympics, the reigning world champion will hope that his spear soars the farthest in the Japanese capital, just as it did in 2021.

No other Indian has gone past Neeraj's Olympic gold-winning mark of 87.58m, but the man himself has 22 throws better than that. After years of being nagged by sections of the media and fans, the Haryana lad finally entered the 90m club this year at the Doha Diamond League with a 90.23m effort, which shows he has stepped up under the guidance of the legendary Jan Zelezny.

At the same time, so has the rest of the world.



Fight to the finish: Animesh Kujur (above) will be the first Indian male sprinter to compete at the World Championships, while triple jumper Praveen Chithravel (right) enters the event with a season's best of 17.37m.

NIRMAL HARINDRAN and NITHIN KRISHNAN

Germany's Julian Weber, the world leader at 91.51m, and Brazilian Luiz Mauricio da Silva (PB/SB: 91m) have emerged as new challengers for Neeraj's throne. In Tokyo, he will also have a familiar rival in Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem, who beat him to the gold at last year's Summer Games with an Olympic record of 92.97m. Since Paris 2024, Arshad has only competed at the Asian Championships, where he won with an 86.40m throw, and underwent a calf muscle surgery in July.

